



NITI Aayog



SECTOR AT A GLANCE 01

Education Sector in India

An Overview

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EDUCATION SECTOR IN INDIA

AN OVERVIEW

DRAFT

The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

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Overview

India has made material progress in increasing access to education across all levels of education. Nearly 8 out of 10 children in the age group of 3 to 6 years old are enrolled in some form of ECCE program¹. The Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) for Upper Primary and Secondary have grown from 85.2% and 65.2% in 2010-11, respectively, to 94.7% and 79.6% in 2021-22.² Enrolment in higher secondary education has increased from 39.4% in 2010-11 to 57.6% in 2021-22.³ Finally, GER in Higher Education has increased steadily from 18.8% in 2010-11 to 27.3% in 2020-21.⁴

India's educational policy agenda aims to establish, by 2040, an inclusive education system that provides high-quality education for all. Aligned with the National Education Policy 2020, the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) is released to match the developmental needs and interests of students at different growth stages. Similar frameworks for early childhood care, the National Curriculum Framework for the Foundation stage is released focusing on holistic development and play-based learning for young children. Frameworks for teacher education, and adult education are also in development. Effective implementation of these frameworks along with other education sector practices can nurture life skills and foundational skills among all, thus creating lifelong learners who can thrive in 21st century regardless of background.

However, India's education sector faces a range of challenges, including a continued reliance on rote learning-based pedagogies, large teacher vacancies at the school level, insufficiency in ECCE teacher training and qualification, lack of employability among students, and inferior perception of vocational education programs.

Given these opportunities and challenges, improving foundational learning outcomes, improving equitable access at secondary and higher education levels, improving employability, and improving quality research are the major policy focus areas. Several ongoing and recent central government initiatives, including but not limited to National Education Policy, National ECCE Policy, Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan, Saksham Anganwadi and Poshan 2.0, and National Apprenticeship Training Scheme focus on ensuring universal and quality education for all.

Promoting holistic learning outcomes through pedagogical innovations, building teacher capabilities, deploying and leveraging technology solutions effectively, advancing equity and inclusion, and improving the efficiency of existing regulations are critical efforts to continue advancing India's education sector. This note covers some high-level trends in various education sub-sectors in India and presents actions for the way forward.

¹ UNICEF, Early childhood education: For school readiness and to build a foundation for lifelong learning, accessed August 2023

² Ministry of Human Resource Development, Educational Statistics - At a Glance, 2016; Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

³ Ministry of Human Resource Development, Educational Statistics - At a Glance, 2016; Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

⁴ Ministry of Education, All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE), 2010-21

Access to education in India (2020-22)

25.57 crore Primary to higher secondary enrolment	12.28 crore Primary to higher secondary enrolment for girls	4.32 crore Enrolment in higher education institutions	2.07 crore Enrolment in higher education institutions for girls
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Gross Enrolment Ratio by level of education (2020-22)

57.6 Senior Secondary (Class 11-12)	27.3 Higher Education	79.6 Secondary (Class 9-10)	57.6 Senior Secondary (Class 11-12)	27.3 Higher Education
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Pupil Teacher Ratio (2021-22)

26.17 Primary	19.45 Upper primary	17.6 Secondary	27.08 Senior secondary	24 University and college institutions (regular mode)
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Infrastructure facilities (2021-22)

98.22% Percentage of schools with drinking water	97.48% Percentage of schools having girls' toilet facility	47.51% Percentage of schools with computer facility	98% Percentage of universities with libraries	93% Percentage of universities with computer centres
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India's Public Expenditure on Education (2020) (% of total government expenditure)

3.9 Primary	5.7 Secondary and Senior Secondary	4.9 Tertiary	14.5 Total
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Source: Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22; Ministry of Human Resource Development, Educational Statistics - At a Glance, 2016; OECD, Education at a glance: Educational finance indicators (2020 or latest available); Ministry of Education, AISHE Final Report 2021-22, 2024

Sub-sectoral trends

This section presents a summary view of all the relevant statistics and trends related to the following sub-sectors within the education sector:

- Early childhood care and education (ECCE)
- School Education
- Higher Education

ECCE

ECCE assumes paramount importance in fostering essential physical, motor, cognitive, and socio-emotional abilities in children and laying the early groundwork for foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) skills.⁵ India has taken significant strides toward improving Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) services. Surveys from UNICEF revealed that nearly 8 out of 10 children in the age group of 3 to 6 years old are enrolled in some form of ECCE program, reflecting the success of India's efforts to expand access to early childhood education.⁶ ECCE in India is provided through (i) Primary schools with pre-primary classes, (ii) Primary schools with Anganwadi Centers (AWC), (iii) Independent AWCs, and (iv) Independent pre-schools/play schools.

Figure: Key ECCE statistics



Source: AWCs- Ministry of Women and Child Development, Poshan Bhi Padhai Bhi, 2023; Children accessing ECCE- Ministry of Women and Child Development, Amount allocated for ECCE under Poshan 2.0, 2022; Teacher with training- Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

Recent policy focus has been on revising curricular structure:

The previous academic structure did not cover children in the age group of 3-6 years.⁷ The Foundational Stage introduced by the National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage (NCF) under NEP 2020 emphasises an integrated approach to ECCE for children between the ages of 3-8.⁸ The Foundational Stage begins at age 3 and ends at age 8 i.e., five years of schooling from preschool to Grade 2.⁹

Malnutrition in children under five has declined marginally in the last two decades:

The percentage of stunted children has reduced from 44.9% in 2005-06 to 35.5% in 2019-21. Similarly, the number of wasted children has fallen from 22.9% in 2005-06 to 19.3% in 2021-22.¹⁰

Digitisation of Anganwadis is witnessing increased policy focus:

99.5% of Anganwadis in India are using the ICDS-Rapid Reporting System (RRS) to digitally monitor physical infrastructure, available manpower and beneficiaries, and financial disbursements.¹¹ In 2019, over 3,55,000 Anganwadi Workers were utilising the ICDS-CAS application across 21 States/UTs to identify underweight children through automated plotting of growth charts.¹² Additionally, in 2022, States/UTs procured a total of 11.03 lakh smartphones to equip 14 lakh Anganwadi Workers (AWWs) with advanced tools for improved service delivery and monitoring in various states.¹³ Further, some states like Tamil Nadu has added an extra worker (Facilitator) dedicated for Early Childhood Education (ECE).¹⁴

School Education

5 Ministry of Education, , National Education Policy , 2020

6 UNICEF, Early childhood education: For school readiness and to build a foundation for lifelong learning, accessed August 2023

7 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

8 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

9 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

10 International Institute for Population Sciences, National Family Health Survey (NFHS) 3, 2005-06; International Institute for Population Sciences, National Family Health Survey (NFHS) 5, 2019-20

11 Ministry of Women and Child Development, Digitization of Data Collected in Anganwadi Centres, 2019

12 Ministry of Women and Child Development, Digitization of Data Collected in Anganwadi Centres, 2019

13 Ministry of Women and Child Development, Smartphone and Tablets to Anganwadi Workers, 2022

14 Alejandro J, Karthik M. Christopher R., Augmenting State Capacity for Child Development: Experimental Evidence from India, 2023

India's school education system is one of the largest in the world. School education in India comprises the following categories: primary level (classes 1-5), upper primary level (classes 6-8), elementary level (classes 1-8), secondary level (classes 9-10), and higher secondary level (classes 11-12).¹⁵ India has made positive strides in the past two decades, achieving 100% access to school education at elementary levels and gender parity.

Figure 1: Key school education statistics

1.48 million

Schools in India

255 million

Students enrolled in schools from primary to higher secondary levels

79.56

Gross Enrolment Ratio at the secondary level

Source: Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22; Ministry of Education, NEP, 2020

High percentage of trained school teachers:

In India, across different levels of school education, the percentage of trained teachers roughly lies at 90%, with variation across states.¹⁶

Improvement in Gender Parity:

The gender parity index in secondary education has progressed, increasing from 0.88 in 2010 to 1 in 2022.¹⁷

Overall physical infrastructure in schools has improved in the last decade:

The availability of hand-washing facilities in schools across India has significantly increased, with approximately 90% of schools having them in 2021-22, a notable improvement from 43% in 2013-14. Furthermore, the presence of playgrounds in schools has also improved, with around 77% of schools having playgrounds in 2021-22 compared to 67% in 2013-14.¹⁸

Higher Education

Over the past two decades, the Indian higher education system has experienced remarkable growth, with a threefold increase in the number of universities, colleges, and standalone institutions.¹⁹ Enrolment in higher education institutes (HEIs) has surged almost fourfold, from around 9 million in 2001 to 41 million in 2022.²⁰

Figure: Key higher education statistics

27.3

Gross Enrolment Ratio in HEIs

INR 44,094 crore

Budget allocation for HE department for FY 2023-24

49%

Female students enrolled in HEIs in 2021

Source: Ministry of Education, All India Survey of Higher Education, 2020-21; Ministry of Education, Ministry of Education has been allocated Rs 112899.47 crore, the highest allocation ever to the Education Ministry – Shri Dharmendra Pradhank, 2023

Government plans to increase multi-disciplinary course offerings in HEIs:

The Ministry of Education aims to have least one large multidisciplinary HEI in or near every district by 2030.²¹ The UGC plans to create multi-disciplinary learning environments by incorporating internships, community service, and skill-based courses on subjects such as entrepreneurship in existing course offerings to increase opportunities for graduate-level jobs across government, industry, and academic circles.²²

¹⁵ Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22; Note: Pre-primary education is covered in the ECCE sub-sector

¹⁶ Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

¹⁷ Ministry of Education, UDISE+, 2021-22; Ministry of Education, Educational Statistics at a Glance, 2018

¹⁸ Ministry of Education, Government of India, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

¹⁹ Ministry of Education, All India Survey of Higher Education, 2020-21

²⁰ Ministry of Education, All India Survey of Higher Education, 2020-21; Brookings, Reviving Higher Education in India, 2019

²¹ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

²² Ministry of Education, Year End Review - Department of Higher Education, 2021

R&D investments, personnel, and associated research output have seen a rise:

India's gross expenditure on R&D (GERD) has consistently been increasing over the years, tripling between 2008 and 2018. Similarly, the number of researchers per MN population has doubled since 2000, with India occupying 3rd rank in the number of Ph. D.'s awarded in Science and Engineering (S&E) after USA and China. Additionally, India's share in global research publication output has increased over the years, with the country being ranked 3rd in scientific publication as per the National Science Foundation (NSF) database.²³

Recent government efforts have focused on improving flexibility in learning and instilling industry-ready skills in graduates:

The Academic Bank of Credits (ABC), set up by the Ministry of Education and the Ministry of Electronics and IT in 2021 enables students to transfer their credits from one program to another, allowing them the flexibility to study at various institutions while pursuing a degree or diploma.²⁴ Till July 2023, about 1 crore ABC student IDs have been created and about 1400 universities and institutions are registered on the portal.²⁵

²³ Ministry of Science & Technology, [India's R&D expenditure & scientific publications on the rise](#), 2020

²⁴ Ministry of Education, [About - Academic Bank of Credits \(ABC\)](#), Accessed July 2023

²⁵ Ministry of Education, [Academic Bank of Credits \(ABC\)](#), Accessed July 2023

Opportunities and challenges

Opportunities



Capacity-building, infrastructure advancement, parent and community engagement, and inclusivity in ECCE

- Improve training for ECCE staff by introducing tailored certification courses and diplomas for Anganwadi workers and teachers, covering early literacy, numeracy, and essential ECCE aspects through a blend of offline and online methods for accessibility and minimal disruption.²⁶
- Enhance Anganwadi centres by constructing child-friendly infrastructure with well-designed indoor and outdoor spaces, ample play materials, essential medical supplies, functional weighing machines, safe drinking water, proper toilets, and effective handwashing amenities.
- Actively promote parental and community involvement in ECCE programs by fostering ongoing positive communication, sharing progress reports, arranging conferences, sending personalized notes, and keeping parents informed about events and activities.²⁷
- Prioritize the inclusion of children with disabilities in ECCE by enhancing infrastructure, providing assistive devices, and conducting disability surveys, fostering collaboration between education ministries and expert bodies like the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities.²⁸



Advancing pedagogical innovation, capacity-building, equity, and governance in school education

- Seize the momentum of recent policy changes emphasizing competency-based learning and a holistic approach by integrating critical thinking, problem-solving, and inquiry-based learning in the curriculum, aligning with the National Curriculum Framework for School Education.²⁹
- Elevate educational outcomes by improving teacher quality through enhanced pre-service and in-service training, real-time assessments with feedback mechanisms, and the establishment of mentorship networks.³⁰
- Address social disparities by establishing free boarding, centralize scholarship information, and adopt tailored approaches for inclusive education, focusing on remote areas and children with disabilities.³¹
- Implement innovative adult education initiatives using existing infrastructures, integrating adult education centers with HEIs, and engaging communities for monitoring and support.³²

²⁶ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

²⁷ NCERT, National Curriculum Framework for Foundational Stage, 2022

²⁸ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

²⁹ NCERT, *NCF School Education*, 2023

³⁰ UNESCO, 2020 vision for India's educational future: teacher quality and the potential of technology, 2020

³¹ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

³² Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

	Optimize resource efficiency and management by establishing school complexes, grouping small school sizes and Anganwadis in a 5-10 km radius.³³
 Enabling pedagogical innovation, capacity-building, R&D, equity, and international mobility in higher education	- Foster interdisciplinary learning and innovative pedagogies through large Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) to bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge and real-world applications, promoting holistic education.³⁴ - Enhance teacher development in India's higher education by implementing merit-oriented career advancement, offering attractive incentives, and fostering continuous support to attract and retain high-quality educators.³⁵ - Foster a research culture in India's higher education by providing seed funding for smaller HEIs' research initiatives and implementing high-quality peer-review processes across disciplines.³⁶ - Improve education access by expanding rural education, offering scholarships, using local languages in the curriculum, promoting online education, and ensuring inclusivity for learners with disabilities.³⁷ - Enhance global standards in higher education by collaborating with international universities, introducing twinning programs, and fostering faculty exchanges for exposure to diverse pedagogies.³⁸

Challenges

 Limited focus on holistic development, insufficient teacher training, and infrastructural limitations in ECCE	- Inadequate emphasis on play-based learning and socio-emotional development in current ECCE curriculum hampers children's holistic development, affecting their emotional intelligence and school readiness.³⁹ - Approximately 1200 AWTCs are required to train all Anganwadi workers, but only 500 AWTCs were operational as per a 2014 report.⁴⁰ Inconsistent and insufficient training for ECCE teachers, lacking practical experience and standardized programs, poses a hurdle to effective early childhood education, with 68% lacking formal training at the pre-primary level in 2021-22.⁴¹ Further, only 1% of private TEIs offer programme for preschool teachers.⁴² - Insufficient access to drinking water (13%) and sanitation facilities (28%) in Anganwadi centers, as reported in a 2019 government submission, hampers their effectiveness in delivering essential services.⁴³
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³³ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

³⁴ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

³⁵ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

³⁶ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

³⁷ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

³⁸ University Grants Commission, Guidelines for Internationalisation of Higher Education in India, 2021

³⁹ NCERT, National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage, 2022

⁴⁰ World Bank, Early Childhood Education in India: A Suggestive Roadmap, 2014

⁴¹ Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

⁴² National Steering Committee for National Curriculum Frameworks, NCF for Foundational Stage, 2022

⁴³ Ministry of Women and Child Development, Modernisation Programme for Anganwadi Centres, 2019



Teacher shortages and training challenges, inclusion barriers, and governance issues in school education

- A nationwide shortage of one million teachers, worsened by urban concentration, coupled with over 17% teacher vacancies in government schools.⁴⁴
- The absence of clear pathways and seamless transitions for students completing Grades 11 and 12 with vocational subjects hinders their effective utilization of skills in the workforce, creating challenges in aligning vocational education with suitable job opportunities.⁴⁵
- Gender norms perpetuate unequal burdens on girls, with many schools lacking basic facilities like girls' toilets, hindering their enrollment and attendance. Additionally, the lack of inclusive infrastructure and differentiated learning approaches poses challenges for Children with Special Needs (CWSNs).⁴⁶
- 34% of total schools (~5 lakh schools) are small schools having less than 50 students. This creates economic inefficiencies, operational challenges, and inefficient infrastructure usage, impacting teacher deployment and resource provision.⁴⁷ Further, currently, more than 10 categories of schools exist leading to various administrative complexities and drop-outs.
- Inadequate commitment to quality teacher education in over 10,000 standalone Teacher Education Institutions (TEIs) raises concerns, with regulatory efforts proving ineffective in curbing malpractices and enforcing quality standards.⁴⁸ This is also highlighted in NEP, which referred TEIs as "Degree selling shops".



Holistic pedagogy, regulatory challenges, and limited integration of vocational education in higher education

- Existing higher education curriculum lacks emphasis on critical soft skills, contributing to varying employability rates across disciplines, with overall employability at 45% according to the India Skills Report 2018.⁴⁹
- Prolonged and bureaucratic faculty recruitment procedures, coupled with time-consuming exams and insufficient incentives, contribute to a scarcity of qualified faculty in higher education institutions.⁵⁰
- Perceived inferiority of vocational education with mainstream education and inadequate teacher training, hinders its enrolment and integration into mainstream education.⁵¹

44 NITI Aayog, Systemic Transformation of School Education-The SATH-E Experience, 2021

45 NCERT, Background note- Reimagining Vocational Education

46 Care India, Policy Brief on Girls' Education, 2021; Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22; UNESCO, State of the Education Report for India - Children with Disabilities, 2019

47 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

48 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

49 UNDP, India Skills Report, 2018

50 Standing Committee on Human Resource Development, Issues and challenges before higher educational sector in India, 2017

51 National Council of Educational Research & Training, Background Paper on Reimagining Vocational Education, 2020; Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

Institutional framework and policy landscape –

Key ministries and departments

Both central and state government policymakers play a key role in the formulation, delivery, and monitoring of education policies and programs across India.

The central government ensures universal access to quality education through the Department of School Education and Literacy, and the Department of Higher Education (DoHE), two nodal departments of the Ministry of Education (MoE). They follow the guiding principles laid down by the National Education Policy (NEP) and carry out various schemes and initiatives aligned with the NEP to actualise the vision of enabling quality and equitable education with an emphasis on disadvantaged sections of society.

One of MoE's largest schemes is the Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA) which was launched in 2018-19, subsuming three erstwhile schemes of the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, including the Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA) and Teacher Education (TE). This scheme covers education from preschool to class XII, harmonising efforts for the development of school education with a focus on improving system-level performance and overall outcomes. Another very critical scheme is the Pradhan Mantri Poshan Shakti Nirman or PM POSHAN scheme renamed in 2021-22 from the erstwhile and historical Mid-day meal scheme. It aims to improve health and nutrition of children in India by providing hot, nutritious meals for students of classes I-VIII in eligible schools, with special attention to disadvantaged/vulnerable children.

Through the Ministry of Women and Child Development (MoCWD), the central government operates the Poshan 2.0 mission (which subsumes the Integrated Child Development Services program). It is one of the largest ECCE programs in the world, delivering preschool education and a host of basic child development services through over a million Anganwadi Centres across India. In 2013, the central government launched the National Early Childhood Care and Education Policy, followed by the National Curriculum Framework and Quality Standards. Together, these documents provide for standardised quality of ECCE services across both public, private, and non-profit actors.

At the state level, the respective school departments of education are primarily involved in policymaking alongside other bodies like State Resource Centres, which provide academic and technical resource support through the development of materials, training modules. State Councils of Educational Research and Training (SCERTs) are responsible for providing academic research and training support for education and assist/advice the department of education in the implementation of policies, and state level training centres which provide teacher education and training services in the state.

Key ministries and departments



शिक्षा मंत्रालय
MINISTRY OF
EDUCATION

Ministry of Education

Formulates and implements policies related to school education, higher education, vocational education, and adult education. The Ministry oversees the development of curriculum frameworks, sets educational standards, and promotes inclusive and quality education for all. It also works on teacher training and professional development, educational infrastructure, and educational research and innovation.



महिला एवं
बाल विकास मंत्रालय
MINISTRY OF
WOMEN AND
CHILD DEVELOPMENT

Ministry of Women and Child Development

Promotes policies and programs that support the establishment and strengthening of early childhood care and education centres, such as Anganwadis, which provide early learning experiences, nutrition, health, and protection to children. It also emphasizes the importance of early stimulation, early literacy, and school readiness by drafting policies and guidelines on early childhood care and education.



Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE)

Regulates and supervises secondary and senior secondary school education in the country. CBSE is responsible for designing the curriculum, developing textbooks, and setting examination standards for affiliated schools. It also focuses on continuous improvement in teaching methodologies, assessment practices, and the overall quality of education. It provides guidance and support to schools, organizes teacher training programs, and encourages innovation in education.



National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)

Develops national curricula frameworks, textbooks, and instructional materials for various school subjects. NCERT conducts research in education, promotes educational reforms, and provides guidance and support to state education departments. The Council also offers training programs for teachers and contributes to the overall enhancement of the quality of education in the country.



National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development (NIPCCD)

Supports the MoWCD with programmatic research, capacity building and advisory for important schemes and in areas of children's holistic development, mental health and protection for ECCE.



National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE)

Ensures planned and coordinated development of teacher education and governs the regulation and proper maintenance of norms and standards for teacher education in India.



University Grants Commission (UGC)

Provides grants to eligible universities and colleges, advises the central and state governments on measures necessary for the development of higher education in India.



National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC)

Conducts assessment and accreditation of Higher Educational Institutions (HEI) such as colleges, universities or other recognised institutions to derive an understanding of the 'Quality Status' of the institution.



National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS)

Provides relevant and holistic education through open and distance learning contributing to universal and equitable school education, along with undertaking research and provide learner support services.



State Councils of Educational Research and Training (SCERTs)

Monitoring and evaluation of the quality of education in schools by setting standards, conducting inspections, and providing guidance on effective school management and administration.

Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing policies related to the education sector and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI Knowledge Platform.

National ECCE Policy, 2013⁵²

The Policy seeks to universalize access to ECCE by providing comprehensive childcare support, infrastructure, and services designed to nurture the overall well-being and developmental needs of children. It aims to raise awareness and foster a common understanding about the significance of ECCE, while also promoting strong collaborations with communities and families to improve the quality of life for young children. Additionally, the policy mandates the provision of safe, child-friendly, and developmentally appropriate play and learning materials.

Saksham Anganwadi and Poshan 2.0, 2021⁵³

The scheme aims to address nutrition related deficiencies and malnutrition among children up to the age of 6 years and promote nutrition awareness and good eating habits for sustainable health and wellbeing.

Pradhan Mantri Poshan Shakti Nirman (also called PM POSHAN), 2021⁵⁴

The primary objective of the scheme is to improve the nutritional status of children studying in classes I-VIII in government or government-aided schools. It also aims to encourage poor children, belonging to disadvantaged sections, to attend school more regularly and help them concentrate on classroom activities.

Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan, 2018-19⁵⁵

The Scheme aims to ensure that all children have access to quality education with an equitable and inclusive classroom environment. This goal is achieved by incorporating child tracking mechanisms for students in government and government-aided school, enhancing the capacity of Teacher Education Institutions such as the State Council of Educational Research and Training (SCERTs) and District Institute of Education & Training (DIETs), and promoting the integration of digital technology in education.

Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009⁵⁶

The act provides for government-sponsored free and compulsory education to all children between 6-14 years of age

National Education Policy (NEP), 2020⁵⁷

The NEP envisions massive transformations in the education system. The Policy aims to universalize the pre-primary education and provides special emphasis on the attainment of foundational literacy/numeracy in primary school and beyond for all by 2025. The Policy also aims to transform the curriculum including pedagogy through a 5+3+3+4 design, catering to children in the age group of 3-18 years. Additionally, the NEP calls for a reform of the current exams and assessment system, strengthen teacher training, and restructure the education regulatory framework. It also seeks to increase public investment in education, strengthen the use of technology and increase focus on vocational and adult education.⁵⁸ For higher education, the policy provides recommendations such as moving towards multidisciplinary and holistic education, institutional autonomy, promotion of quality research, internationalization of higher education, etc.

⁵² Ministry of Women and Child Development, National ECCE Policy, 2013

⁵³ Ministry of Women and Child Development, Saksham Anganwadi and Poshan 2.0, 2021

⁵⁴ Department of School Education & Literacy, Ministry of Education, PM POSHAN SHAKTI Nirman (PM-POSHAN), 2021

⁵⁵ Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education, Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan, 2018-19

⁵⁶ Ministry of Education, Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009

⁵⁷ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

⁵⁸ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

National Means-cum-Merit Scholarship Scheme (NMMSS), 2008-09⁵⁹

The scheme provides scholarships for meritorious students of classes IX-XII to reduce dropouts.

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⁵⁹ Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education, National Means-cum-merit Scholarship Scheme, 2008

Way forward

Over the past few decades, and more recently with the NEP, India has made substantial progress on advancing educational equity and quality for all learners through pedagogical, regulatory, and capacity-building-related reforms. However, as highlighted in the above sections, much more progress is required to realize the NEP's ambitions of turning India into a global knowledge superpower. Some key areas of intervention for energy policymakers going forward include the following:



Enhance ECCE delivery through age-appropriate and holistic learning, stronger teacher training, and community involvement

- **Increase emphasis on age-appropriate learning & inculcate flexibility in adoption of guiding ECCE frameworks:** Policymakers can do so by facilitating state-specific adoption of ECCE frameworks, developing localized teaching materials, and ensuring a continuum of learning across the foundational stage with greater inter-departmental coordination.
- **Strengthen training and qualification systems for ECCE teachers:** Such efforts involve policymakers standardizing ECCE teacher training programs, ensuring regular training, incorporating ECCE programs in existing TEIs, and improving incentive and monitoring systems for high-performing teachers.
- **Increase parental and community participation in ECCE education:** The aim is to boost community involvement through Anganwadi workers/helpers by enabling them to organize community-based events, facilitating local decision-making to develop community centers for child play, and creating incentive structures for proactive community participation.
- **Increase parent inclusion in early childhood education programs:** Such efforts involve raising awareness about the importance of early childhood education and nutrition, and establishing continuous engagement channels with parents to assess their child's progress both online and offline.



Advance foundational learning outcomes, optimize school systems, enhance teacher capabilities, promote digital solutions, and ensure inclusive school education

- **Monitor and advance student learning outcomes:** Policymakers should accelerate foundational literacy and numeracy, build parental awareness, and shift towards competency-based assessments with constructive feedback.
- **Improve governance and administrative systems:** Policymakers should optimize school resourcing by establishing school complexes and sharing resources, and build an individualized tracking system for student learning outcomes.
- **Rationalize sub-scale schools without compromising on accessibility:** To enhance school governance, resource utilization, and peer learning, policymakers should consider rationalizing schools without compromising accessibility. This approach ensures that schools remain easily accessible to students while maximizing efficiency and collaboration among educational institutions. Additionally, providing transportation allowances can further improve accessibility, particularly in remote areas or regions with limited transportation options.

	- Strengthen teacher capacity: Policymakers should strengthen recruitment processes, ensure adequate resources for teacher training, conduct needs assessments, and provide continuous professional development opportunities. - Promote the adoption of digital learning solutions: Policymakers should enhance digital infrastructure, advance open-source digital solutions, and promote a high-quality digital learning ecosystem with AI and machine learning-enabled platforms. - Ensure equity and inclusion: Policymakers should increase enrolment, retention, and transition rates for girls, and provide inclusive quality education for Children with Special Needs (CWSNs) by customizing educational content and investing in conducive infrastructure.
 Advance quality, foster innovation, increase access, improve faculty training, and advance internationalisation in higher education	- Continue enhancing quality assurance: Policymakers should encourage the clustering of Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) to create multidisciplinary institutes and strengthen accreditation systems by promoting third-party, credible accreditation agencies. - Enable greater research and innovation: Policymakers should incentivize the quality of research output by enhancing policy guidelines and improve research financing by enabling industry, policy, and civil society linkages. - Accelerate multidisciplinary curricular offerings: Policymakers should make teaching-learning more relevant and interdisciplinary, accelerate the uptake of online courses, and integrate vocational education into mainstream Higher Education (HE). - Increase access, equity, and affordability: Policymakers should ensure equitable access to quality higher education among Socio-Economically Disadvantaged Groups (SEDGs), enhance student loan financing options, and support HEIs in creating more degree programs taught in Indian languages and bilingual formats. - Enhance faculty training and incentives: This includes adopting stringent faculty recruitment processes and norms, attracting talented educators, and strengthening pre-service faculty training efforts. - Advance state capacity for internationalisation: Such efforts include enhancing inter-ministerial coordination and monitoring, defining and monitoring performance benchmarks for international universities, and developing an enabling regulatory, accreditation, and partnership ecosystem to attract international campuses.

Recommended readings

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